Farmer Corn Brief

Week of October 15, 2026

> **Week of October 15, 2026**
> Nearby corn: $4.808/bu (-$0.195 (-3.9%) week)
> Narrative created: October 16, 2026

Nearby futures from Yahoo Finance. Nearby corn is the market's current perception of yield and demand risk.

Contract	Last	Week change	As of
Nearby corn	$4.808/bu	-$0.195 (-3.9%)	October 14, 2026
RBOB gasoline	$3.260/gal	-0.057 (-1.7%)	October 14, 2026
Henry Hub	$3.198/MMBtu	+0.030 (+0.9%)	October 14, 2026

Where we are

Harvest is moving again, but USDA changed the crop before Nebraska reached full flow. The October estimate is now **16.034 billion bushels at 181.2 bushels per acre**, up 234 million bushels and 2.7 bushels from September. Projected 2026/27 ending stocks rose 282 million bushels to **1.849 billion**, even after USDA added 125 million bushels of use. Nebraska yield jumped from 177 to **188 bushels per acre**, raising estimated state production roughly 106 million bushels to **1.807 billion**. (USDA WAOB, *WASDE-676*, October 9, 2026; USDA NASS, *Crop Production*, October 9, 2026) (esmis.nal.usda.gov)

Nearby corn—now December—finished October 14 at **$4.8075 per bushel**, down **19½ cents**, or **3.9%**, from October 8. March settled at **$4.9425**, leaving **13½ cents of December-to-March carry**. (CME Group, *Corn Futures Quotes*, October 14, 2026) (cmegroup.com)

National harvest reached **33%**, versus a 39% five-year average. Nebraska advanced from 15% to **27% harvested**, still behind the 35% average. (USDA NASS, *Crop Progress*, October 13, 2026)

(esmis.nal.usda.gov)

The week in one page

- **USDA reversed the smaller-crop thesis.** Instead of the trade's expected 177.7-bushel yield and 15.721-billion-bushel crop, USDA printed 181.2 and 16.034 billion. Carryout landed 179 million bushels above the pre-report trade average. (Pro Farmer, *Market Snapshot: Grains Mostly Firmer Ahead of USDA*, October 9, 2026; USDA, *WASDE-676*, October 9, 2026) (profarmer.com)
- **Nebraska's change was more bearish than the national revision.** The state yield increased **11 bushels** from September. That argues against holding all remaining bushels for a local short-crop rally, even though dryland and irrigated results still vary by field.
- **The board confirmed the heavier supply.** Nearby December lost **19½ cents** to $4.8075. This was not procurement deterioration. It was a lower selling opportunity caused by more expected corn.
- **Deferred basis is better than spot basis at several processors.** Against the October 14 board, nearby bids were roughly 25 to 30 under at ADM Columbus, Cargill Blair and Green Plains Central City, while December delivery was roughly 5 to 15 under. The buyer is offering part of the storage return through basis. (Farmbucks, *CVA Nebraska Cash Bids*, October 14, 2026) (farmbucks.com)
- **Ethanol plants kept running, but inventories increased.** Production rose 12,000 barrels per day to **1.065 million**, while stocks increased 199,000 barrels to **23.942 million**. That supports corn disappearance without forcing plants to chase harvest bushels. (Ethanol Producer Magazine, *EIA Weekly Data: Ethanol Production Up 1%, Stocks Up 1%*, October 15, 2026) (ethanolproducer.com)
- **Verdict:** This week made it harder to raise your average sale price. USDA added both national and Nebraska bushels, and the board removed 19½ cents. Protect rebounds. Let firm deferred basis—not hope—justify storage.

1. USDA replaced the smaller-crop regime with a heavier one

What happened

The prior working view was that additional harvest evidence might pull USDA below its September yield of 178.5. Instead, USDA raised yield to **181.2**, production to **16.034 billion bushels**, and total supply to

18.154 billion. Higher projected exports and domestic use absorbed 125 million bushels, but supply increased 407 million. Carryout therefore rose to **1.849 billion bushels**, with an 11.3% stocks-to-use ratio. (USDA, *WASDE-676*, October 9, 2026) (esmis.nal.usda.gov)

Nebraska's estimate moved even more. USDA raised yield from 177 to **188 bushels**, putting production at **1.8067 billion bushels**. That does not mean every dryland field recovered. It means strong acres—particularly irrigated acres—were sufficient to lift the state total sharply. (USDA NASS, *Crop Production*, October 9, 2026; UNL CropWatch, *Nebraska Crop Production Report for October 2026*, October 12, 2026) (esmis.nal.usda.gov)

Why it matters for a long-corn producer

The market now has more cushion against disappointing demand or later field losses. A rally needs either a November yield reversal, stronger-than-expected disappearance, or outside-market help. Routine reports of variable yields will not overturn an 11-bushel Nebraska increase.

What to do with it

Stored old-crop: Sell firm basis. The September stocks increase already weakened the case for carrying 2025 corn. The larger 2026 crop weakens it further.

2026 crop: Re-size production from actual combine results. On a rebound, cover more breakeven with an HTA, short hedge or cash contract. Avoid making a panic futures sale after a 19½-cent break, but do not wait for $5 simply because it traded there last week.

Watch next

The November 10 WASDE and continued harvest yields must show that October overstated production before the smaller-crop thesis can be rebuilt.

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2. The board removed value and left only modest carry

What happened

December fell from $5.0025 to **$4.8075**. March at $4.9425 provides **13½ cents of carry**, or about 4½ cents per month before interest, shrink, handling and bin costs.

Why it matters for a long-corn producer

The board is telling you the October supply increase matters. The carry is useful, but it does not pay for automatic storage. Most bins still need basis improvement or a favorable deferred cash bid to produce a return.

What to do with it

Unpriced corn: Treat a recovery toward the pre-report area as a selling opportunity, not proof USDA was wrong. Establish floors if you cannot tolerate another leg lower.

Stored corn: Do not roll merely to postpone the decision. Capture carry only when the cash spread pays full ownership costs.

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3. Deferred processor bids are doing more work than nearby basis

What happened

On October 14, ADM Columbus bid **$4.51 nearby and $4.76 for December**; Cargill Blair bid $4.56 nearby and **$4.71 for December**; Green Plains Central City bid **$4.54 nearby and $4.66 for December**. Against $4.8075 December futures, nearby basis calculates to roughly 25 to 30 under, while December delivery was approximately 5 to 15 under. March cash bids produced gross nearby-to-March spreads of roughly **24 to 30 cents** at those locations. (Farmbucks, *CVA Nebraska Cash Bids*, October 14, 2026) (farmbucks.com)

Why it matters for a long-corn producer

There is no broad harvest basis squeeze. However, several buyers are paying meaningfully better basis for later delivery. About half the gross cash spread comes from board carry; the rest comes from the basis schedule.

What to do with it

At 25 to 30 under nearby, avoid giving away basis if you have economical space. At 5 to 15 under for December delivery, the forward cash bid deserves attention. You can lock the buyer's basis improvement rather than binning corn with both futures and basis open.

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4. Harvest momentum returned, so the delayed-bushel window is narrowing

What happened

Nebraska producers had **6.3 suitable fieldwork days** during the week ended October 11. Corn harvest advanced 12 points to 27%. National harvest advanced 10 points to 33%. Both remain behind normal, but the gap is shrinking. (UNL CropWatch, *Nebraska Crop Progress: Harvest Gains Momentum*, October 13, 2026; USDA NASS, *Crop Progress*, October 13, 2026) (cropwatch.unl.edu)

Why it matters

Wet-weather logistics temporarily limited nearby movement. A full fieldwork week means more corn is now reaching elevators and plants just as USDA increased the Nebraska crop. Any local basis premium caused by delayed deliveries can disappear quickly.

What to do with it

Reward short-lived delivery specials. Do not store corn solely because harvest had been late. If the elevator or plant offers near-even deferred basis, make it compete against your bin.

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5. Ethanol demand held, but it did not rescue the cash bid

What happened

Ethanol output rose to **1.065 million barrels per day**, but stocks also increased to 23.942 million barrels. RBOB gasoline lost **5.7 cents per gallon**, while natural gas gained 3 cents per MMBtu during the week.

Why it matters

Plants continue to consume corn at a solid rate. The inventory increase and weaker gasoline screen reduce the urgency to improve basis during harvest. The posted bid remains the deciding evidence.

What to do with it

Keep shopping ethanol plants. Sell strong basis when it appears. Do not assume steady production will repair a 20-cent futures loss.

The crop you still have to market

Old-crop in bins: Clear it against firm basis. Larger beginning stocks and a larger new crop leave little reason to carry 2025 bushels without a contracted return.

2026 crop: Confirm production, then protect more futures on rebounds. Separate the basis decision where spot bids remain 25 to 30 under. Use firm December basis where offered.

The running RP harvest-price estimate is about **$4.92**, still above the $4.62 projected price. If that relationship survives the full October average, it helps insured yield losses. It does not price normal-yield bushels sitting unhedged in the bin. (AGSIST, *2026 Harvest Price Tracker*, accessed October 15, 2026) (agsist.com)

Bottom line

The decision changed because USDA added **234 million production bushels**, raised Nebraska yield **11 bushels**, and pushed carryout to **1.849 billion**. The board responded by taking away **19½ cents**.

Do not dump weak basis after the break. Do not remain fully open either. Protect rebounds, reward near-even deferred processor basis, and make the cash spread pay before you bin corn.